PHOTO ESSAY / NORTHERN KENYA

A Lake Under Pressure

Water. Livelihoods. Cooperation.

Life around Lake Turkana, told through the people who depend on it.

A man draws water from a shallow well in a dry river bed.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

A desert lake. Many ways of life.

In arid northern Kenya, families, pastoralists and fishing communities rely on a small number of wells and rivers. When these water sources weaken, the lake becomes even more central to daily life.



A family homestead in the Lake Turkana region.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

“Water is the number one natural resource.”

Narogoe Ebenyo Maisa
Pastoralist and chair, Kibish Water Resource User Association

The water table has fallen as rainfall has declined, making reliable water harder to find.

Narogoe Ebenyo Maisa speaks about water access in Kibish.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

When a river bed runs dry

A shallow well can become the difference between getting through the day and going without. Water collection is part of the rhythm of home, work and caring for livestock.



A resident fetches water from a shallow well in a dry river bed.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

Fishing takes skill, patience and teamwork.

Along the shore, fishing supports local food and livelihoods. Preparing nets and going out together are part of the daily work of communities around the lake.

Fishermen prepare nets at Impresa beach, Kalokol.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

The lake’s value travels beyond shore.

Fish drying in the sun is a visible link between the lake and household livelihoods. The work continues after the boats return, as the catch is prepared and preserved.



Fish dry at Impresa beach in Kalokol town.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

Scarcity is shared by people and livestock.

Drought and unreliable water sources can push families to move and bring different needs together at the same wells and shorelines. Where access is tight, competition can turn into conflict.



Goats search for pasture in the dry landscape.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

Shared resources need shared decisions.

Water user groups, community leaders and local partners create ways to discuss access and manage pressure. Listening locally helps decisions reflect the people who live with the consequences.

A community meeting with local partners in the Lake Turkana area.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

Dialogue can change what happens next.

“The WPS project is engaging the community … to forge peaceful coexistence.”

Charles Losike
Plumber and vice chair, Kibish Water Association

Charles Losike, Kibish Water Association.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

A WAY FORWARD

Protect the water. Strengthen the ties.

Listen to the people closest to the water.
Support fair, dependable access.
Keep dialogue open across communities.

Resilience grows when shared resources are managed together.



Residents transport supplies in Kalokol.

PHOTO: MARTIN MWANGI / INTERNATIONAL ALERT

PHOTO CREDITS / SOURCES

The story behind the photographs.

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Community dialogue is part of managing shared water resources.

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